

Chapter 5 — When People Revolt: 1857 and After

The one-line point: A cartridge lit it, but a **century of dispossession** had laid the fuel. Within weeks it stopped being a mutiny and became "**some regard it as the biggest armed resistance to colonialism in the nineteenth century anywhere in the world.**" And when it ended, **the Company was abolished.**

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Modern India
Sub-discipline	Revolt of 1857 ; the transition from Company to Crown
Period	1857 – 1859 , with the Khurda case study of 1817
Prelims (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ <i>History of India</i> → leaders, centres, dates, the post-1857 changes
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ ★ "The Freedom Struggle — its various stages and important contributors from different parts of the country" — 1857 is the standard opening stage
Also feeds	Polity ★ ★ (Government of India Act 1858 — Secretary of State, India Council, Viceroy), Indian Society (communal policy after 1857), Ethics (loyalty and rebellion)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ ★ ★ — among the most-asked single events in Indian history
Overlaps with	Class 12 Theme 10 (<i>Rebels and the Raj</i> — the advanced treatment), Ch.2 (Awadh, Doctrine of Lapse), Ch.8

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **List the grievances** of rulers, peasants and sepoys separately. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain** the **1824 Burma order** and the **1856 service law**. ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain** the **religious-reform grievance**, including the **1850 conversion law**. ★ ★
- ☐ **Narrate the outbreak** — **Mangal Pandey, Meerut, Delhi** — with exact dates. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain** why **Bahadur Shah Zafar's acceptance transformed the revolt**. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Match every leader to their centre**. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Narrate the suppression** with dates and fates. ★ ★
- ☐ **List the SIX post-1857 changes**. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Distinguish a mutiny from a popular uprising**, and say what turns one into the other. ★ ★
- ☐ **Narrate the Khurda (Paika) Uprising of 1817** — causes, course, outcome. ★ ★
- ☐ **Use the two primary sources** (Vishnubhatt Godse, Sitaram Pande) as evidence. ★ ★

Start Here: What Turns a Mutiny into an Uprising

NCERT gives a definition worth memorising, because it is the analytical spine of the chapter:

★ **MUTINY** = "when soldiers as a group disobey their officers in the army."

★★★ **But:** *"sometimes such struggles become quite **widespread as a POPULAR RESISTANCE** so that **THE POWER OF THE STATE BREAKS DOWN**. A very large number of people begin to believe that **they have a COMMON ENEMY** and **rise up against the enemy AT THE SAME TIME**. For such a situation to develop, people have to **ORGANISE, COMMUNICATE, TAKE INITIATIVE** and **DISPLAY THE CONFIDENCE** to turn the situation around."*

THE FOUR CONDITIONS:

ORGANISE | COMMUNICATE | TAKE INITIATIVE | BE CONFIDENT

...plus the belief in a COMMON ENEMY, and SIMULTANEITY.

★★★ **This is the answer to "was 1857 a mutiny or a war of independence?"** — and NCERT hands you the framework rather than the slogan. **It began as a mutiny (soldiers disobeying officers) and became a popular uprising (the state's power breaking down over a region)**. Use the four conditions to show *how* the transition happened. That is a far better answer than picking a label.

★★ ★ The Grievances — Three Groups

Nawabs and rajas lose their power

*"Since the mid-eighteenth century, nawabs and rajas had seen their power erode. **Residents had been stationed in many courts, the freedom of the rulers reduced, their armed forces disbanded, and their revenues and territories taken away by stages.**"* (*All of Chapter 2, in one sentence.*)

★★★ The three refusals that created three rebel leaders:

Petitioner	The request	The outcome
★★★ RANI LAKSHMIBAI of JHANSI	That the Company recognise her ADOPTED SON as heir after her husband's death	Refused
★★★ NANA SAHEB , adopted son of Peshwa Bajji Rao II	That he be given his father's PENSION when the latter died	Refused
★ AWADH	—	Subsidiary alliance imposed 1801; annexed 1856 on Dalhousie's declaration of " misgovernment "

★ "However, the Company, **confident of its superiority and military powers, turned down these pleas.**" **Both refusals produced leaders of the revolt.** (*And note the Bithur connection from Class 7 Ch.8 — Bajji Rao II was pensioned off to Bithur near Kanpur in 1818; his son leads Kanpur in 1857.*)

★★★ And the plan to end the Mughal dynasty:

Step	Detail
The coins	"The name of the Mughal king was REMOVED from the coins minted by the Company"
★ 1849, Dalhousie	After Bahadur Shah Zafar's death, the family would be shifted OUT OF THE RED FORT and given another place in Delhi
★★ 1856, Canning	Bahadur Shah Zafar would be the LAST MUGHAL KING ; after his death none of his descendants would be recognised as kings — they would just be called PRINCES

🎯 **Removing the emperor's name from the coinage was a deliberate act of desecralisation — coinage is the classic assertion of sovereignty (Class 7 Ch.8). The Company was formally erasing the Mughal claim just as it was about to need someone to blame for reviving it.**

🏡 The peasants

*"In the countryside, **peasants and zamindars resented the HIGH TAXES and the RIGID METHODS of revenue collection. Many failed to pay back their loans to the moneylenders and gradually LOST THE LANDS they had tilled for generations.**" (All of Chapter 3.)*

🇮🇳 ★ ★ ★ The sepoys

Grievance	Detail
Basic conditions	"They were unhappy about their pay, allowances and conditions of service. "
★★ Religious sensibility	"Some of the new rules violated their religious sensibilities and beliefs. " Many believed that crossing the sea meant losing religion and caste
★★ 1824	Sepoys ordered to go to BURMA by the SEA route refused — " though they agreed to go by the LAND route " — and were severely punished
★★★ 1856	Because the issue did not die down, the Company passed a new law: every new recruit had to agree to SERVE OVERSEAS if required
★★ The link to the countryside	*"Many of them were PEASANTS and had families living in the villages. So the anger of the peasants quickly spread among the sepoys. "*

★★★ **That last row is the hinge of the whole chapter, and the best single insight to carry into an answer.**

The sepoy was not a separate professional caste — he was a peasant in uniform. Every grievance of the countryside travelled straight into the barracks through family letters. **That is why a soldiers' mutiny could become a peasants' rebellion within weeks: they were the same people.**

🔗 **And recall Chapter 2's warning:** the army was built on **European drill and discipline that ignored caste and community feeling**, with NCERT asking "*could they see themselves ONLY as soldiers and NOT as members of communities?*" **1857 is the answer to that question.**

🏠 ★ ★ Responses to reform

*"The British believed that Indian society **had to be reformed.**"*

Measure	Detail
Laws	To stop sati and to encourage the remarriage of widows
Education	★ English-language education actively promoted
★ After 1830	The Company allowed Christian missionaries to function freely in its domain, and even own land and property
★★ 1850	A new law made conversion to Christianity EASIER — it allowed an Indian who had converted to inherit the property of his ancestors

★★ **The consequence, in NCERT's own words:** *"Many Indians began to feel that the British were DESTROYING THEIR RELIGION, THEIR SOCIAL CUSTOMS AND THEIR TRADITIONAL WAY OF LIFE."**

⚠️ **But NCERT immediately balances it:** *"There were of course other Indians who WANTED to change existing social practices."* → Chapter 7.

🎯 **Hold both halves.** The reforms were experienced by many as an attack on religion **and** were demanded by Indian reformers themselves. **A good answer refuses to flatten this into either "benevolent reform" or "cultural aggression".**

2 ★★ **Through the Eyes of the People — Two Primary Sources**

These are gold, because they let you quote Indians rather than officials.

★ **Source 1 — Vishnubhatt Godse, *Majha Pravaas***

A **Brahman from a village in Maharashtra**, travelling with his uncle to a *yajna* at Mathura, met sepoys who told him not to proceed because **an upheaval would break out in three days**:

*"The English were determined to wipe out the religions of the Hindus and the Muslims... they had made a list of EIGHTY-FOUR RULES and announced these in a gathering of all big kings and princes in Calcutta... the kings refused to accept these rules and warned the English of dire consequences... A DATE WAS FIXED FOR THE WAR OF RELIGION and the secret plan had been circulated from the cantonment in MEERUT by letters sent to different cantonments."**

★★ **Source 2 — Subedar Sitaram Pande, *From Sepoy to Subedar***

About him	Detail
Recruited	1812, into the Bengal Native Army
Served	48 years, retiring in 1860
★ His position	<i>"He helped the British to suppress the uprising though his own son was a rebel and was killed by the British in front of his eyes"</i>
The memoir	Written in 1861 in AWADHI ; his commanding officer Norgate translated and published it

*"It is my humble opinion that **THIS SEIZING OF OUDH** filled the minds of the Sepoys with **DISTRUST** and led them to plot against the Government... They worked upon the feelings of sepoys, telling them how treacherously the foreigners had behaved towards their king..."*

And on the cartridges: *"a report got about... that the cartridges used for these new rifles were **greased with the fat of cows and pigs**. The men from our regiment **wrote to others...** and **there was soon EXCITEMENT IN EVERY REGIMENT**. Some men pointed out that **in forty years' service nothing had ever been done by the Sarkar to insult their religion**, but... **the sepoys' minds had been INFLAMED BY THE SEIZURE OF OUDH.**"*

★ ★ ★ Sitaram Pande's testimony is exceptionally valuable, and here is why you should use it:

He was **loyal to the British, lost his own son to them, and still names the annexation of Awadh as the cause**. A hostile witness confirming the grievance is the strongest kind of evidence.

And his sequence is the correct historical one: the cartridge did not cause the revolt — it detonated a charge that Awadh had already laid. He says so explicitly: nothing in forty years had insulted their religion, *but* their minds had already been inflamed by the seizure of Oudh.

★ **Note also the communication mechanism** in both sources — **letters circulated between cantonments**, rumour travelling faster than administration. Compare the *chapati* and the Queen Victoria rumour of Chapter 3: **rumour was the network on which mobilisation ran.**

3 ★ ★ ★ From Meerut to Delhi — the Outbreak

Learn these dates exactly. They are asked directly.

*** 8 APRIL 1857 ***

MANGAL PANDEY hanged to death for attacking his officers
at BARRACKPORE

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*** 9 MAY 1857 ***

At MEERUT, sepoy had refused to do the drill using the new
cartridges, "suspected of being coated with the FAT OF COWS
AND PIGS".

*** EIGHTY-FIVE SEPOYS were DISMISSED from service and
SENTENCED TO TEN YEARS IN JAIL for disobeying orders. ***

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*** 10 MAY 1857 -- "The response of the other Indian soldiers
in Meerut was quite EXTRAORDINARY" ***

- marched to the JAIL and RELEASED the imprisoned sepoy
- attacked and KILLED BRITISH OFFICERS
- captured GUNS AND AMMUNITION
- SET FIRE to British buildings and properties
- *** DECLARED WAR ON THE FIRANGIS ***

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"But WHO WOULD RULE THE LAND INSTEAD? The soldiers had an
answer -- *** THE MUGHAL EMPEROR BAHADUR SHAH ZAFAR. ***"

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*** THE NIGHT OF 10 MAY: the sepoy RODE ALL NIGHT to reach
DELHI in the early hours of 11 May ***

- regiments stationed in Delhi ALSO ROSE
- officers killed, arms seized, buildings burnt
- troops gathered at the RED FORT walls DEMANDING TO MEET
the Badshah
- "The emperor was NOT QUITE WILLING to challenge the mighty
British power BUT THE SOLDIERS PERSISTED. They FORCED
THEIR WAY INTO THE PALACE and PROCLAIMED Bahadur Shah
Zafar as their leader."

★ **FIRANGIS = foreigners** — *"the term reflects an attitude of contempt."*

🎯 **Notice the crucial detail: the soldiers had an answer to "who rules instead?"** A mutiny without
an alternative is a riot. **The moment they named a sovereign, it became a political project.**

★★★ **Why Bahadur Shah Zafar's acceptance changed everything**

The ageing emperor had to accept. *"He wrote **letters to ALL THE CHIEFS AND RULERS of the
country to come forward and organise a CONFEDERACY OF INDIAN STATES to fight the
British. This single step taken by Bahadur Shah had GREAT IMPLICATIONS.**"*

WHY IT MATTERED:

"The Mughal dynasty had ruled over a VERY LARGE PART of the country. *** MOST SMALLER RULERS AND CHIEFTAINS CONTROLLED DIFFERENT TERRITORIES ON BEHALF OF THE MUGHAL RULER. ***

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Threatened by the expansion of British rule, many of them felt that *** IF THE MUGHAL EMPEROR COULD RULE AGAIN, THEY TOO WOULD BE ABLE TO RULE THEIR OWN TERRITORIES ONCE MORE, UNDER MUGHAL AUTHORITY. ***"

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"The British had NOT EXPECTED this to happen. They thought the disturbance caused by the cartridges WOULD DIE DOWN. But *** Bahadur Shah Zafar's decision to BLESS THE UPRISING CHANGED THE ENTIRE SITUATION DRAMATICALLY. *** Often when people SEE AN ALTERNATIVE POSSIBILITY, they feel INSPIRED AND ENTHUSED. It gives them the COURAGE, HOPE AND CONFIDENCE TO ACT."

☆☆☆ This is the single most important analytical passage in the chapter.

The Mughal emperor was **politically powerless but constitutionally central** — the fiction under which dozens of Indian rulers held their legitimacy. **Reviving the fiction gave every dispossessed raja a legal theory for his own restoration.** It converted scattered grievances into **a single alternative sovereignty.**

 The Mughal throne was a **shared authority anchor**. Everyone's claim ultimately chained back to it. Reactivating the root **re-validated every claim beneath it at once.**

☆ NCERT's own question — "why did the Mughal emperor agree to support the rebels?" — is **worth thinking about honestly.** He was reluctant; he was old; he was about to be the last of his line by Canning's 1856 decision. He had **nothing left to protect and one thing left to be.**

☆☆☆ The Uprising Spreads — Leaders and Centres

*"After the British were routed from Delhi, **there was no uprising for almost a week. IT TOOK THAT MUCH TIME FOR NEWS TO TRAVEL.** Then, a spurt of mutinies began."*

****Regiment after regiment mutinied and joined troops at nodal points like DELHI, KANPUR and LUCKNOW. Then "the people of the towns and villages also rose up in rebellion and rallied around local leaders, zamindars and chiefs."**

★ ★ ★ The leaders — memorise this table

Leader	Centre	Detail
★ ★ ★ Bahadur Shah Zafar	DELHI	Proclaimed leader; wrote to all chiefs to form a confederacy
★ ★ ★ NANA SAHEB	KANPUR	Adopted son of the late Peshwa Baji Rao , living near Kanpur; gathered forces and expelled the British garrison ; ★ proclaimed himself PESHWA and declared he was a GOVERNOR UNDER Emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar
★ ★ BIRJIS QADR	LUCKNOW	Son of the deposed Nawab Wajid Ali Shah ; proclaimed the new Nawab ; ★ also acknowledged the suzerainty of Bahadur Shah Zafar
★ ★ ★ BEGUM HAZRAT MAHAL	LUCKNOW	Birjis Qadr's mother ; ★ "took an active part in organising the uprising against the British"
★ ★ ★ RANI LAKSHMIBAI	JHANSI	Joined the rebel sepoys and fought the British
★ ★ TANTIA TOPE	Kanpur / central India	★ The general of Nana Saheb
★ ★ RANI AVANTIBAI LODHI	RAMGARH, Mandla region of Madhya Pradesh	★ Raised and led an army of FOUR THOUSAND against the British who had taken over her state's administration
★ ★ AHMADULLAH SHAH	Faizabad → Lucknow	★ A maulvi from FAIZABAD who prophesied that British rule would soon end ; <i>"caught the imagination of the people and raised a huge force"</i>
★ ★ BAKHT KHAN	Bareilly → DELHI	★ A soldier from BAREILLY who took charge of a large force and became a key military leader of the uprising
★ ★ KUNWAR SINGH	BIHAR	★ An OLD ZAMINDAR who joined the rebel sepoys and battled the British for many months
Ghazis	Delhi	<i>"A large number of ghazis or religious warriors came together"</i>

🧠 **Memory hook by place:** Delhi–Zafar & Bakht Khan • Kanpur–Nana Saheb & Tantia Tope • Lucknow–Birjis Qadr & Begum Hazrat Mahal • Jhansi–Lakshmibai • Ramgarh–Avantibai • Faizabad–Ahmadullah Shah • Bihar–Kunwar Singh.

★ ★ **Note the pattern of legitimacy:** Nana Saheb called himself a **governor under Bahadur Shah Zafar**; Birjis Qadr **acknowledged his suzerainty**. The rebels were **building a chain of authority, not just fighting**. That is evidence for the "more than a mutiny" argument.

★ **And note three women leading armed forces** — Lakshmibai, Hazrat Mahal, Avantibai. Excellent for a GS1 question on women in the national movement.

★ ★ Why the revolt spread — and the telegram

*"The British were **greatly outnumbered** by the rebel forces. They were **defeated in a number of battles**. This **convinced the people that the rule of the British had collapsed for good** and **gave them the confidence to take the plunge and join the uprising**."*

★ ★ **The telegram of 6 August 1857**, from **Lieutenant Colonel Tytler** to his Commander-in-Chief:

"Our men are cowed by the numbers opposed to them and the endless fighting. EVERY VILLAGE IS HELD AGAINST US, THE ZAMINDARS HAVE RISEN TO OPPOSE US."

★ ★ ★ **Quote this.** It is the British themselves confirming the revolt had passed beyond the army: **every village, and the zamindars.** That single line does more to establish "popular uprising" than any assertion could.

🌀 **And notice the feedback loop:** British defeats convinced people the Raj had collapsed → which brought more people in → which produced more defeats. **Success recruited.** The same dynamic runs in reverse during the suppression.

5 ★ ★ The Company Fights Back

*"Unnerved by the scale of the upheaval, the Company decided to **repress the revolt with all its might.** It brought reinforcements from England, passed new laws so that the rebels could be convicted with ease, and then moved into the storm centres of the revolt."*

Event	Date	Detail
★ ★ Delhi recaptured	September 1857	(A 7-mile-long siege train of cannon and ammunition pulled by elephants arrived on 3 September 1857)
★ ★ Bahadur Shah Zafar tried	—	Sentenced to LIFE IMPRISONMENT ; he and his wife Begum Zinat Mahal sent to prison in ★ RANGOON in October 1858
★ ★ Zafar died	★ November 1862, in the Rangoon jail	
★ ★ Lucknow taken	★ March 1858	
★ ★ ★ Rani Lakshmibai	★ Defeated and killed in JUNE 1858	
★ Rani Avantibai	—	After an initial victory at Kheri , she chose to embrace death when surrounded on all sides
★ ★ Tantia Tope	★ Captured, tried and killed in APRIL 1859	Escaped to the jungles of central India and continued a ★ GUERRILLA WAR with the support of many tribal and peasant leaders

★ "The recapture of Delhi did NOT mean that the uprising died down." *"The British had to fight for TWO YEARS to suppress the massive forces of popular uprising."*

★ ★ Carrot and stick:

*"Just as victories against the British had earlier encouraged uprising, **the defeat of rebel forces encouraged DESERTIONS.** The British also tried their best to **win back the loyalty of the people.** They announced **rewards for loyal landholders**, who would be allowed to **continue to enjoy traditional rights over their lands.** Those who had rebelled were told that **if they submitted, and if they had NOT KILLED ANY WHITE PEOPLE, they would remain safe** and their **rights and claims to land would not be denied.**"*

⚠️ ***"Nevertheless, hundreds of sepoys, rebels, nawabs and rajas were TRIED AND HANGED."***

🌀 NCERT's question — "how did the British succeed in securing the submission of the rebel landowners of Awadh?" — is answered exactly here: by **guaranteeing their land rights** if they submitted. **Land was the currency of both rebellion and reconciliation.**

6 ★ ★ ★ Aftermath — The Six Changes

*"The British had **regained control of the country by the end of 1859**, but **they could not carry on ruling the land with the same policies any more.**"*

★ ★ ★ Learn all six. This is guaranteed exam content.

- [1] *** THE GOVERNMENT OF INDIA ACT, 1858 ***
The British Parliament TRANSFERRED THE POWERS OF THE EAST INDIA COMPANY TO THE BRITISH CROWN, "in order to ensure a more responsible management of Indian affairs".
- A member of the British Cabinet was appointed
*** SECRETARY OF STATE FOR INDIA *** , responsible for all matters of Indian governance
- He was given an advisory council, the *** INDIA COUNCIL ***
- The Governor-General was given the title *** VICEROY *** , "a personal representative of the Crown"
=> "the British government accepted DIRECT RESPONSIBILITY for ruling India."
- [2] *** NO MORE ANNEXATION ***
All ruling chiefs were assured their territory would NEVER BE ANNEXED in future, and could PASS ON THEIR KINGDOMS TO THEIR HEIRS, *** INCLUDING ADOPTED SONS. ***
BUT they had to acknowledge the British Queen as their *** SOVEREIGN PARAMOUNT *** -- holding their kingdoms as SUBORDINATES of the British Crown.
- [3] *** THE ARMY RESTRUCTURED ***
- the proportion of INDIAN soldiers would be REDUCED
- the number of EUROPEAN soldiers INCREASED
- instead of recruiting from AWADH, BIHAR, CENTRAL INDIA and SOUTH INDIA, more soldiers would come from the *** GURKHAS, SIKHS and PATHANS ***
- [4] *** MUSLIMS TARGETED ***
"The LAND AND PROPERTY OF MUSLIMS was CONFISCATED ON A LARGE SCALE and they were treated with SUSPICION AND HOSTILITY. The British believed that they were responsible for the uprising in a big way."
- [5] *** RELIGIOUS NON-INTERFERENCE ***
"The British decided to RESPECT THE CUSTOMARY RELIGIOUS AND SOCIAL PRACTICES of the people in India."
- [6] *** LANDLORDS PROTECTED ***
"Policies were made to PROTECT LANDLORDS AND ZAMINDARS and give them SECURITY OF RIGHTS OVER THEIR LANDS."

★ ★ ★ **Read changes [2], [5] and [6] together and the logic is unmistakable.** The British identified their two fatal mistakes — **annexing states** and **appearing to attack religion** — and reversed both. Then they **bought the loyalty of the landed class** with security of tenure.

The post-1857 Raj was built on an alliance with princes and landlords, and a promise not to interfere in religion. That is why the later national movement had to be led by **a new English-educated middle class** rather than by the old elites — the old elites had been **bought**. **This is the direct bridge to Chapter 8.**

★ **Change [3] is the origin of the "martial races" doctrine** — recruitment shifted to communities judged loyal in 1857, and away from Awadh and Bihar, which had rebelled. It shaped the Indian Army for a century.

★ ★ **Change [4] is the origin of a long and consequential policy shift.** Muslims were held disproportionately responsible; land was confiscated; and the community was treated with hostility for decades — a fact that matters when you reach **the founding of the Muslim League and the politics of Partition** in Chapter 8. **NCERT states it plainly and so should you, without embroidery.**

🔗 **Polity crossover:** the **Government of India Act 1858** created the **Secretary of State, the India Council and the Viceroy** — the constitutional architecture that runs to 1947. Cross-reference with your Polity notes on the evolution of the Indian constitution.

7 ★ ★ Case Study: The Khurda (Paika) Uprising, 1817

A newer NCERT addition and genuinely current-affairs relevant — the Paika Rebellion has been the subject of major commemoration, and there has been public debate about calling it a "first war of independence".

The background

Fact	Detail
Where	KHURDA , a small kingdom in the south-eastern part of ORISSA , built in the late 16th century
Its size	105 garhs, 60 large and 1,109 small villages at the start of the 19th century
Earlier losses	Raja Birakishore Dev had been forced to give the Marathas four <i>parganas</i> , the superintendence of the JAGANNATH TEMPLE , and the administration of fourteen <i>garjats</i>
★ The betrayal	His successor MUKUNDA DEV II , sensing opportunity in the Anglo-Maratha conflict , negotiated with the British to recover his territories and rights over the Jagannath Temple . ★ But after the British occupied Orissa in 1803 they showed no inclination to oblige him on either score
The consequence	He tried to assert his rights by force, in alliance with other feudatory chiefs and with secret Maratha support → deposed, territories annexed ; left only with management of the Jagannath Temple and a grant of one-tenth of his former revenue , residing at Puri

🔗 **Note the Jagannath Temple again** — Class 7 Ch.7 told you that "*all those who conquered Orissa, including the English East India Company, attempted to gain control over the temple.*" **Here is that story from the other side.**

★★ The causes of the 1817 uprising

[1] "The British followed a policy of RESUMING SERVICE TENURES.
*** It bitterly affected the lives of the EX-MILITIA of the state, the PAIKS. ***"

[2] An UNREASONABLE INCREASE in the revenue demand, and OPPRESSIVE ways of collecting it
-> "LARGE SCALE DESERTION of people from Khurda between 1805 and 1817"

[3] A series of SHORT-TERM SETTLEMENTS, "each time INCREASING THE DEMANDS, *** NOT RECOGNISING either the PRODUCTIVE CAPACITY of the land or the PAYING CAPACITY of the ryots ***"

[4] "*** NO LENIENCY was shown even in case of NATURAL CALAMITIES ***, which Orissa was frequently prone to. Rather, LANDS OF DEFAULTERS WERE SOLD OFF to scheming revenue officials or SPECULATORS FROM BENGAL."

PLUS four further grievances:

- (a) the introduction of the *** SICCA RUPEE *** (silver currency)
- (b) the insistence on payment of revenue IN THE NEW CURRENCY
- (c) an unprecedented RISE IN THE PRICES OF FOOD-STUFF AND SALT, following the *** SALT MONOPOLY *** which deprived Orissa's traditional salt makers of making salt
- (d) the AUCTION OF LOCAL ESTATES IN CALCUTTA, which brought *** ABSENTEE LANDLORDS FROM BENGAL *** into Orissa

...and "the INSENSITIVE AND CORRUPT POLICE SYSTEM".

★★ This list is a compact catalogue of everything Chapter 3 described — over-assessment, no relief in calamity, land sold to outsiders, absentee landlords — **plus a currency change and a salt monopoly.**

🎯 The salt monopoly is worth flagging: it deprived **traditional salt makers of Orissa** of their livelihood and raised prices. **The same grievance Gandhi would choose for the Salt March in 1930.**

★★ The leader and the course

Fact	Detail
★★ The leader	JAGABANDHU BIDYADHAR MAHAPATRA BHARAMARABAR RAI , popularly ★ BUXI JAGABANDHU — the hereditary Military Commander of the deposed king , himself among the dispossessed landholders
★ His condition	"He had <i>in effect become a beggar</i> , and for <i>nearly two years survived on voluntary contributions from the people of Khurda</i> before deciding to fight for their grievances as well as his own"
★★ The outbreak	★ 29 MARCH 1817 — the Paiks attacked the police station and other government establishments at BANPUR , killing more than a hundred men and taking a large amount of government money
The spread	Ripples spread with Khurda as the epicentre ; ★ zamindars and ryots alike joined the Paiks ; those who did not were taken to task ; a ★ "NO-RENT CAMPAIGN" was started
★★ 14 April 1817	Buxi Jagabandhu , leading five to ten thousand Paiks and men of the KANDH tribe , SEIZED PURI and declared the hesitant king Mukunda Dev II as their ruler. ★ The priests of the Jagannath Temple extended full support
Suppression	The British clamped ★ MARTIAL LAW ; the king was captured and imprisoned at Cuttack ; Major-General Martindell was sent in; hundreds of Paiks were killed , many fled to the jungles, some returned under an amnesty . By May 1817 the uprising was mostly contained
★ The long tail	Outside Khurda it was sustained by Buxi Jagabandhu with help from the Raja of Kujung and the loyalty of the Paiks until his surrender in MAY 1825

★ ★ The outcome — and why it matters

Afterwards the British adopted a policy of ★ "leniency, indulgence and forbearance" towards the people of Khurda:

- The price of salt was reduced
- Necessary reforms were made in the police and justice systems
- Corrupt revenue officials were dismissed
- ★ Former landholders were restored to their lands
- The king's son **Ram Chandra Dev III** was allowed to move to Puri and take charge of the **Jagannath Temple** with a grant of **twenty-four thousand rupees**

★ ★ ★ NCERT's closing judgement, and it is pointed:

*"In sum, it was the **first such popular anti-British armed uprising in Orissa**, which had **far reaching effect on the future of British administration** in that part of the country. **To merely call it a 'Paik Rebellion' will thus be an UNDERSTATEMENT.**"*

🎯 Two exam-relevant points:

1. **It was popular, not merely military** — zamindars, ryots, the Kandh tribe and the temple priests all joined, and there was a **no-rent campaign**. That is the "mutiny → popular uprising" test from the start of this chapter, met **forty years before 1857**
2. **It won concessions** — salt prices cut, land restored, officials dismissed. **Resistance produced results**, exactly as with the jhum cultivators and Birsa in Chapter 4

★ **The chapter's placement is deliberate:** it shows that *"resentment against the colonial policies of the British had been **building up since the beginning of the 19th century in different parts of the country**" — 1857 was not the beginning of resistance, only its largest instance.*

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Mutiny (definition) ★	Soldiers as a group disobeying their officers
Lakshmibai's demand ★★	Recognition of her adopted son as heir — refused
Nana Saheb's demand ★★	His father Baji Rao II's PENSION — refused
1849 / 1856 Mughal decisions ★★	Dalhousie : family to leave the Red Fort after Zafar's death. Canning : Zafar the last king ; successors merely princes
1824 ★	Sepoys refused to go to Burma by SEA ; punished
1856 law ★★	Every new recruit must agree to serve overseas
1850 law ★★	A convert to Christianity could inherit ancestral property
After 1830	Missionaries allowed to function freely and own property
Mangal Pandey ★★★★	Hanged 8 April 1857 at BARRACKPORE
Meerut ★★★★★	9 May: 85 sepoy s dismissed and given 10 years . 10 May : revolt
Delhi ★★	Sepoys rode overnight; Bahadur Shah Zafar proclaimed leader
Firangi	Foreigner (contemptuous)
Leaders ★★★★★	Nana Saheb (Kanpur , proclaimed Peshwa , "governor under Zafar"), Birjis Qadr & Begum Hazrat Mahal (Lucknow) , Lakshmibai (Jhansi), Tantia Tope (Nana Saheb's general), Rani Avantibai Lodhi (Ramgarh, army of 4,000), Ahmadullah Shah (maulvi of Faizabad), Bakht Khan (soldier from Bareilly), Kunwar Singh (old zamindar, Bihar)
Tytler's telegram ★★	6 August 1857 — " <i>every village is held against us, the zamindars have risen</i> "
Suppression dates ★★★★	Delhi Sept 1857; Lucknow March 1858; Lakshmibai killed June 1858; Zafar to Rangoon Oct 1858, died Nov 1862; Tantia Tope killed April 1859; control regained end of 1859
★★★★ The six changes	1858 Act (Secretary of State, India Council, Viceroy); no more annexation , adopted sons allowed, Queen as Sovereign Paramount ; fewer Indian, more European soldiers , recruitment from Gurkhas, Sikhs, Pathans ; Muslim land confiscated ; religious non-interference ; landlords protected
Sitaram Pande ★★	Recruited 1812 , served 48 years , retired 1860 ; wrote in Awadhi ; blamed the seizure of Oudh
Vishnubhatt Godse ★	<i>Majha Pravaas</i> ; the " eighty-four rules " rumour; letters from Meerut
★★ Khurda 1817	Buxi Jagabandhu , the PAIKS ; began 29 March 1817 at BANPUR ; Puri seized 14 April ; martial law; Martindell ; surrendered May 1825 ; won lower salt prices and restored lands

Traps:

- "The revolt began at Meerut on 10 May with no prior incident" → Mangal Pandey was hanged on 8 April at Barrackpore, and 85 sepoy's were sentenced on 9 May
- "Bahadur Shah Zafar led the revolt enthusiastically" → FALSE. He was "not quite willing"; the soldiers forced their way into the palace

- "Zafar was executed" → **FALSE**. Life imprisonment, exiled to **Rangoon**, died **1862**
- "Nana Saheb declared independence from the Mughals" → **FALSE**. He declared himself **a governor under Bahadur Shah Zafar**
- "After 1857 the British annexed more states" → **FALSE**. They **promised never to annex again** and allowed **adopted heirs**
- "After 1857 the proportion of Indian soldiers was increased" → **FALSE**. **Reduced**; Europeans increased
- "The Khurda uprising was a purely military mutiny of the Paiks" → **FALSE**. Zamindars, ryots, the **Kandh tribe** and **temple priests** joined; there was a **no-rent campaign**

Mains

- ★★★★★ "1857 began as a mutiny and became a popular uprising." Examine — use NCERT's four conditions (organise, communicate, initiative, confidence) plus **Tytler's telegram**
- ★★★★★ "The greased cartridge was the occasion, not the cause, of the Revolt of 1857." Discuss — **Sitaram Pande** is your best evidence
- ★★★★★ "The post-1857 settlement determined the shape of the national movement that followed." — princes and landlords bought off, religion left alone, army recomposed; hence a **new middle-class leadership** in Ch.8
- ★★ **Polity**: the **Government of India Act 1858** and the constitutional architecture of the Raj
- ★★ **Women in history**: Lakshmibai, Hazrat Mahal, Avantibai
- ★ **Regional resistance**: the **Paika/Khurda uprising of 1817** as evidence that anti-colonial resistance long predated 1857

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Mutiny	Soldiers as a group disobeying their officers
Firangi	Foreigner — a contemptuous term
Ghazi	A religious warrior
Viceroy	The personal representative of the Crown in India, from 1858
Secretary of State for India	The Cabinet member responsible for Indian governance after 1858
Sovereign Paramount	The supreme authority Indian rulers had to acknowledge
Paik	The ex-militia of Khurda
Garh	A fort/territorial unit
Sicca rupee	The silver currency introduced in Orissa
Martial law	Military rule replacing ordinary law
Siege train	A convoy of cannon and ammunition for besieging a fortified place

2-MINUTE RECAP

1. A **mutiny** is soldiers disobeying officers; a **popular uprising** is when the state's power breaks down because many people believe they face a **common enemy** and act **at the same time** — requiring them to **organise, communicate, take initiative and be confident**.

2. **Rulers' grievances: Lakshmibai's adopted heir and Nana Saheb's pension** both refused; **Awadh annexed in 1856** for "misgovernment"; the emperor's name **removed from the coinage**, and **Canning's 1856 decision** that Zafar would be the **last king**.
3. **Peasants' grievances: high taxes, rigid collection, debt, and loss of ancestral land** (Chapter 3).
4. ★ **Sepoys' grievances:** pay and conditions; the **1824 refusal to sail to Burma**; the **1856 law compelling overseas service**; and above all that **sepoys were peasants with families in the villages, so rural anger travelled straight into the barracks**.
5. **Reform grievances:** *sati* and widow-remarriage laws, **English education, missionaries free to own property after 1830**, and the **1850 law letting converts inherit** — though **other Indians actively wanted reform**.
6. ★ **Sitaram Pande**, a loyal 48-year veteran whose own son was killed as a rebel, blamed **the seizure of Oudh**, noting that in forty years nothing had insulted their religion before.
7. ★★ **The outbreak: Mangal Pandey hanged 8 April at Barrackpore; 9 May, 85 Meerut sepoy jailed for ten years; 10 May, the Meerut regiments freed them, killed officers and declared war on the *firangis*; they rode overnight to Delhi and forced Bahadur Shah Zafar to lead them.**
8. ★★★ **Zafar's acceptance transformed everything**, because most smaller rulers held their territories **on behalf of the Mughal ruler** — so his restoration promised **theirs**. He wrote to all chiefs to form a **confederacy**.
9. **The leaders: Nana Saheb** (Kanpur, "governor under Zafar"), **Birjis Qadr and Begum Hazrat Mahal** (Lucknow), **Lakshmibai** (Jhansi), **Tantia Tope, Rani Avantibai** (4,000 men), **Ahmadullah Shah** (Faizabad), **Bakht Khan** (Bareilly), **Kunwar Singh** (Bihar).
10. ★ **Tytler's telegram, 6 August 1857:** *"Every village is held against us, the zamindars have risen to oppose us."*
11. **Suppression: Delhi September 1857, Lucknow March 1858, Lakshmibai killed June 1858, Zafar exiled to Rangoon October 1858 and died there in 1862, Tantia Tope killed April 1859. Two years of fighting; control regained by the end of 1859. Rebels who submitted and had killed no white people kept their land — but hundreds were tried and hanged.**
12. ★★★ **The six changes of 1858:** Crown rule via the **Government of India Act** (Secretary of State, India Council, Viceroy); **no further annexation and adopted heirs allowed**, with the Queen as **Sovereign Paramount**; **fewer Indian and more European troops**, recruited from **Gurkhas, Sikhs and Pathans**; **Muslim property confiscated** and the community treated with hostility; **religious non-interference**; and **protection of landlords and zamindars**.
13. ★★ **Khurda, 1817:** the **Paiks** under **Buxi Jagabandhu** rose on **29 March at Banpur, seized Puri on 14 April** with **Kandh** support and the **Jagannath priests**, ran a **no-rent campaign**, and were suppressed under **martial law** — but won **cheaper salt, police and judicial reform, and restored lands**. He held out until **May 1825**. NCERT: *"to merely call it a 'Paik Rebellion' will be an understatement."*

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. What was the demand of Rani Lakshmibai that the British refused? → *That the Company recognise her adopted son as heir to Jhansi.*
2. Consider the following statements:
 1. Mangal Pandey was hanged at Barrackpore on 8 April 1857.
 2. At Meerut, 85 sepoy were sentenced to ten years' imprisonment on 9 May 1857.

3. Bahadur Shah Zafar readily agreed to lead the revolt. → *1 and 2 only. He was "not quite willing"; the soldiers forced their way into the palace.*
3. Consider the following pairs:
1. Begum Hazrat Mahal — Lucknow
 2. Kunwar Singh — Bihar
 3. Bakht Khan — Jhansi → *1 and 2 only. Bakht Khan was a soldier from **Bareilly** who became a key military leader at **Delhi**.*
4. Which of the following changes followed the revolt of 1857?
1. The powers of the East India Company were transferred to the Crown.
 2. Ruling chiefs were allowed to pass their kingdoms to adopted sons.
 3. The proportion of Indian soldiers in the army was increased. → *1 and 2 only. The proportion of Indian soldiers was **reduced**.*
5. The Khurda uprising of 1817 was led by — → *Buxi Jagabandhu, hereditary military commander of the deposed king, at the head of the Paiks.*
6. Bahadur Shah Zafar spent his last years — → *Imprisoned in Rangoon from October 1858, where he died in November 1862.*

Mains style

7. "The greased cartridge was the occasion, not the cause, of the Revolt of 1857." Critically examine. **(250 words)**
8. "1857 began as a mutiny and became a popular uprising." Discuss, with evidence. **(250 words)**
9. Assess the significance of Bahadur Shah Zafar's acceptance of the rebels' offer. **(150 words)**
10. "The British response to 1857 shaped the character of the national movement that followed." Examine. **(250 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Give the three groups of grievances, with two examples each.
- State the dates of Barrackpore, the Meerut sentencing, and the Meerut rising.
- Why did Zafar's acceptance matter so much?
- Name eight leaders and their centres.
- List the six post-1857 changes.
- Give three causes and three outcomes of the Khurda uprising.